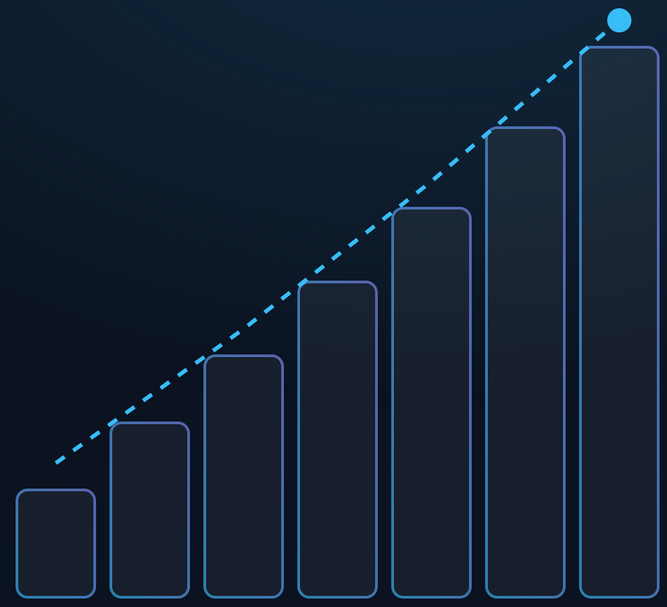
JOHOR STATE · EARLY FINDINGS FOR DISCUSSION

From data lake to better services.

What Johor can learn from **China's digital-government journey**, and what to build next.

October 2026



WHY NOW

Three pressures make this the right time to act.

42

The data-centre boom

Data-centre projects approved as of Q2 2025, worth RM164bn. Investors expect approvals to be fast and predictable.

Jan 2025

The Johor–Singapore SEZ

Agreement signed. IMFC-J now coordinates investor approvals across federal and state agencies.

Now

The state data lake

Being built today. It gives Johor the data foundation that most of China's reforms had to create first.

The pressure lands on approvals, investor facilitation and council services, which are exactly where a data lake can help.

Sources: Johor state announcements reported by The Sun and Malay Mail (July 2025); the JS-SEZ agreement (7 January 2025).

THE QUESTION

The data lake is the foundation. What do we build on it?

We looked for projects that serve at least one of three goals, and sorted them by how soon they can deliver.

Less paperwork

Citizens and businesses stop bringing documents that government already holds, and make fewer visits.

Faster processing

Approvals, licences and permits move in days, not weeks, with progress anyone can see.

New services and investment

New services that draw investment and make daily life better for local businesses and residents.

WHAT WE LOOKED AT

We studied five Chinese regions that moved from paper to data-driven government.

Zhejiang

"At Most One Visit": a citizen visits government at most once per matter.

Shanghai

One online front door, and digital certificates that replace photocopies.

Shenzhen

Instant approval for low-risk, rule-based applications.

Suzhou

Small businesses get loans based on government-held records.

Beijing

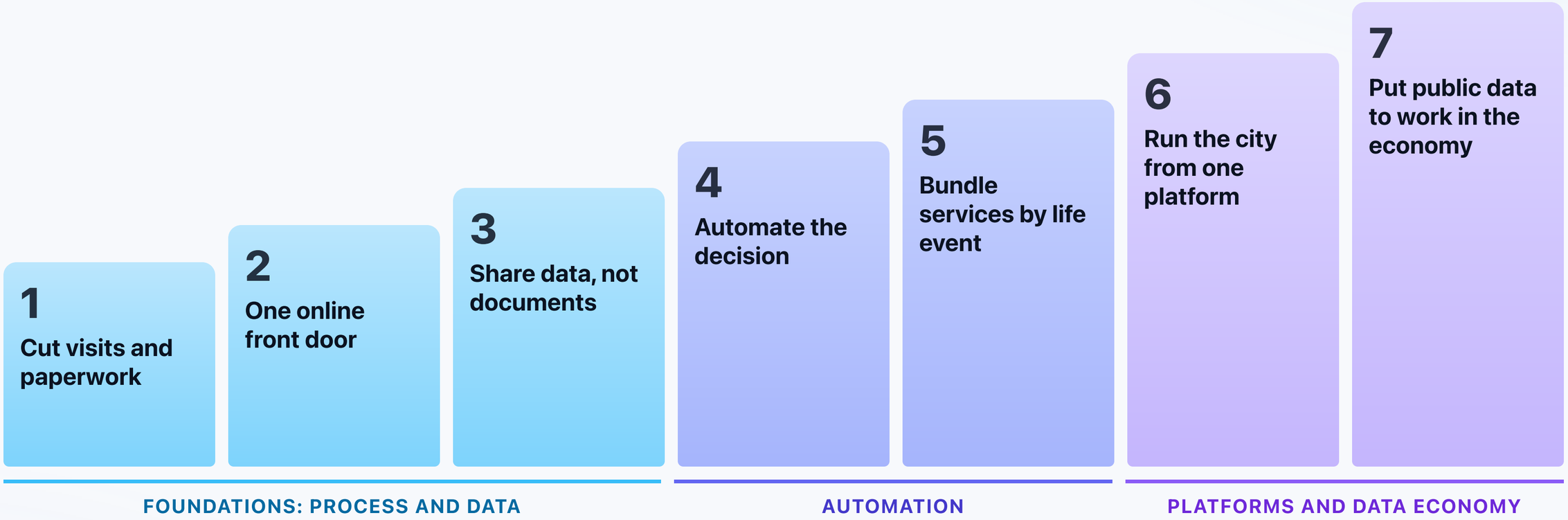
One complaints hotline whose data sets the city's priorities.

Why China: it has gone furthest on this journey at city and provincial scale, and its failures are as instructive as its successes.

A caveat: most results are government-reported (2017–2024). We treat them as direction, not proof.

THE JOURNEY

China went in seven stages, and the order matters.



Stages 1–3 are cheap compared with what comes after, and every later stage depends on them.

WHERE JOHOR STANDS

Johor has already started on several stages.

STAGE	WHAT JOHOR HAS TODAY	STATUS
1 **Cut visits and paperwork**	Council counters; OSC 3.0 Plus for building permits	Started
2 **One online front door**	Separate portals for each council; MyDigital ID at federal level	Partial
3 **Share data, not documents**	The state data lake (new); the Data Sharing Act covers federal bodies only	Being built
4 **Automate the decision**	—	Not yet
5 **Bundle by life event**	IMFC-J for investors	Partial
6 **Run the city from one platform**	Command centres in the city councils (MBJB, MBIP)	Partial
7 **Public data in the economy**	—	Not yet

Based on public sources. To be confirmed with the state, starting with what the data lake holds today.

LESSONS

What worked in China, and what didn't.

WORKED	DIDN'T WORK
The **process changed first**, then the technology followed	Technology laid on top of unchanged paper processes
One front door on a channel people already use	One app per department, with downloads made compulsory
Running costs funded from day one, with a named operator	Turnkey packages that went idle after launch
Outcomes **measured and published**: days, visits, cases resolved	Success reported only by the supplier
Data used only for its **stated purpose**, with consequences for misuse	Data repurposed, and public trust lost

WHAT TRANSFERS

Borrow China's sequence, not its enforcement.

What transfers well

- The order: process and data before platforms and AI
- "One visit" targets and life-event bundles, which are commitments, not mandates
- Rule-based approval with a manual fallback
- Writing reforms into state rules, so they outlast leadership changes

Johor's realities

- Federal, state and 16 councils agree by consensus, not by mandate
- The Data Sharing Act 2025 covers federal agencies only, not the state
- Two-speed citizens: physical counters must stay open
- Little in-house technical capacity in the district councils

Don't import: blacklisting or pervasive surveillance. Both would cost the data lake public trust.

OPPORTUNITIES

Opportunities fall into three buckets.

Quick wins

Mostly process, and data already held

"One visit" baseline

visits, documents and days for the top council services

Data-centre and SEZ approval tracker

one status view across agencies

Complaints insight

existing council complaints, seen state-wide

Foundations

Shared building blocks that unlock the rest

State data-sharing framework

the legal and practical basis to share

Digital licences and permits

verifiable records instead of photocopies

Shared reference data

one ID for each business, property and person

Strategic

New services and investment draw

Instant approval for low-risk renewals

with a manual fallback

Life-event bundles

e.g. "build a data centre in Johor"

Water and power monitoring

to support data-centre approvals

Examples only. A fuller longlist is ready for the validation stage.

THE CRITICAL PATH

The critical path is a state data-sharing framework.

The data lake
Storage: data held in one place

→

+ A state data-sharing framework
A state directive or enactment, a data catalogue, and standard agreements between state, councils and federal bodies

→

Shared, trusted data
The base for quick wins, automation and new services

Why Johor needs its own

The Data Sharing Act 2025 covers federal public-sector bodies only. Any data flow between state agencies, the 16 councils and federal bodies needs its own legal basis.

Without it, the data lake is storage. With it, the data lake is the foundation for everything else.

HOW TO DELIVER

Six principles for how to deliver it.

1

The state owns; an operator runs

Government keeps the data, the rules and the outcomes. A dedicated operator builds and runs the platform.

2

Shared services for councils

District councils use shared services, rather than each buying its own package.

3

Fund running costs, not just the build

The biggest failures were systems nobody was paid to run after launch.

4

Measure use, not launches

Usage and outcome targets set from day one, and published.

5

Write reforms into state rules

So that the reforms outlast changes in leadership.

6

Keep the right to change operators

Choose operators competitively, with term limits and an exit clause, and keep the data with the state.

TO VALIDATE

Questions to answer next.

The data lake

Which datasets does it hold today, from which agencies and councils, and who owns it?

Authority to share

Which body can direct data sharing across all 16 councils, and is there appetite for it?

Pilot councils

Which two or three councils would volunteer to go first?

Existing plans

Where does the Johor Digital Master Plan 2030 stand, and which targets are reported today?

Investor approvals

Does IMFC-J track cases in a system that could be connected, or is tracking manual?

Opening data

How much appetite is there for consent-based sharing with banks, or for opening data to the public?

NEXT STEP

A short validation workshop is the next step.

1

Confirm the starting point

What the data lake holds, who owns it, and what each council runs today.

2

Choose the priorities

Pick three to five items across the three buckets, with the data-sharing framework on the critical path.

3

Agree pilots and a baseline

Name the pilot councils, and the visits, documents and days to measure progress against.

Outcome: a prioritised roadmap for the state, built on what Johor already has.